CHAPTER 24

IN CONTROL

5–8 June 2008

ENGLAND vs NEW ZEALAND, 3rd Test, *Trent Bridge, Nottingham*

England 364; New Zealand 123 and 232 (following on)

England won by an innings and 9 runs

New Zealand 1st innings: **J Anderson 21.3–8–43–7**

I have never felt more in control of what I am doing with a cricket ball. It's like it has shown itself with glaring clarity in reaction to the world outside showing the opposite. There is a sweet relief to having a cricket ball in my hand. It will do what I tell it to do. I can see it move before I bowl it, see the shape of a batter turned inside out, hear the sound of the ball hitting the stumps. In the third Test of the summer against New Zealand, I am batting number nine. I score 28. Everything on a cricket pitch is tangible, effectible. I have a hunger to exercise my ability to shape what happens, suddenly impaired by the reality of how difficult anything outside can be to shape.

Aaron Redmond is opening for New Zealand. I run in – watch the ball out of my hand, seam perfectly upright, standing to attention, doing what it is told to do. Redmond sees that line, the one that makes a right-hander assume it is straight and can be flicked away. He opens his body to do so and, as if there's an anti-magnetic reaction, the ball suddenly hoops, evading his outside edge, cleaning up his stumps. He is staring back, confused. The sound rings out around Trent Bridge.

Next up is Brendon McCullum – the key wicket. I run in, imagining the same. Everything happens as if it is a choreographed repeat sequence of the last wicket. The straightening up, the wild swinging of the ball, the slightly